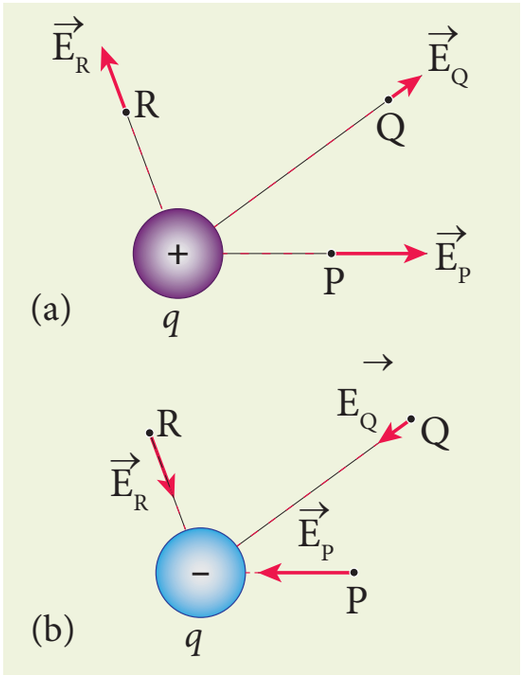


Figure 1.6 (a) Electric field due to positive charge (b) Electric field due to negative charge

(v) In the definition of electric field, it is assumed that the test charge q_0 is taken sufficiently small, so that bringing this test charge will not move the source charge. In other words, the test charge is made sufficiently small such that it will not modify the electric field of the source charge.

(vi) The expression (1.4) is valid only for point charges. For continuous and finite size charge distributions, integration techniques must be used These will be explained later in the same section. However, this expression can be used as an approximation for a finite-sized charge if the test point is very far away from the finite sized source charge. Note that we similarly treat the Earth as a point mass when we calculate the gravitational field of the Sun on the Earth (refer unit 6, volume 2, XI physics).

(vii) There are two kinds of the electric field: uniform (constant) electric field and non-uniform electric field. Uniform electric field will have the same direction and constant magnitude at all points in space. Non-uniform electric field will have different directions or different magnitudes or both at different points in space. The electric field created by a point charge is basically a non uniform electric field. This non-uniformity arises, both in direction and magnitude, with the direction being radially outward (or inward) and the magnitude changes as distance increases. These are shown in Figure 1.7.

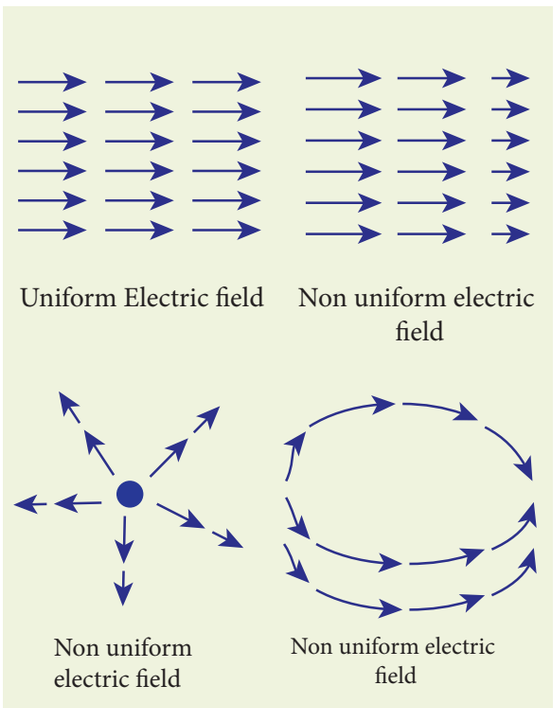


Figure 1.7 Uniform and non-uniform electric field

EXAMPLE 1.6

Calculate the electric field at points P, Q for the following two cases, as shown in the figure.

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